





PHOTOGRAPHY ▼

THE WEIGHT OF GRACE

Rajesh Bedi's *Elephant: The Divine Mystery* is a luminous ode to the elephant and to a lifetime spent in reverent pursuit of the wild

Baba Bohrd'—a Punjabi term for a sprawling banyan tree and an undisputed master—befits Rajesh Bedi perfectly. Gaunt, gentle and stoic, with eyes that observe more than they see and a beard with its own quiet antiquity, Bedi stands as India's most revered chronicler of the wild. Through his lens, the country's wilderness has found its visual mythology.

Along with his brother Naresh Bedi, he pioneered wildlife photography and filmmaking in India at a time when the field was still an uncharted frontier. For Bedi, photography was never mere documentation—it was discovery, born of patience, intuition, and a deep study of animal behaviour.

His seventh book, *Elephant: The Divine Mystery*, is a tender, almost devotional portrait of one of Earth's most sentient beings—the elephant—whom Bedi fondly calls his "first love", his "girlfriend". Through five decades of wandering forests, wading through streams, holding oneself in a zen-like stillness, and often braving razor-close proximity to danger—even while being stung by blood-sucking flies—he has amassed a portrait of the elephant that is intimate, surprising and deeply moving. His elephants emerge from morning mists like deities—their wrinkled hides a cartography of ancient memory. We see an endearing elephant family in a 'group hug'; dust-baths that transform giants into playful children; the underside of a bathing elephant's foot glowing like carved jasper. Where others capture spectacle, Bedi seeks revelation: exceptional unseen images of sleeping elephants, aerial shots of herds swimming across flooded rivers, or a closeup of a coiled trunk

ELEPHANT: THE DIVINE MYSTERY

by Rajesh Bedi
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